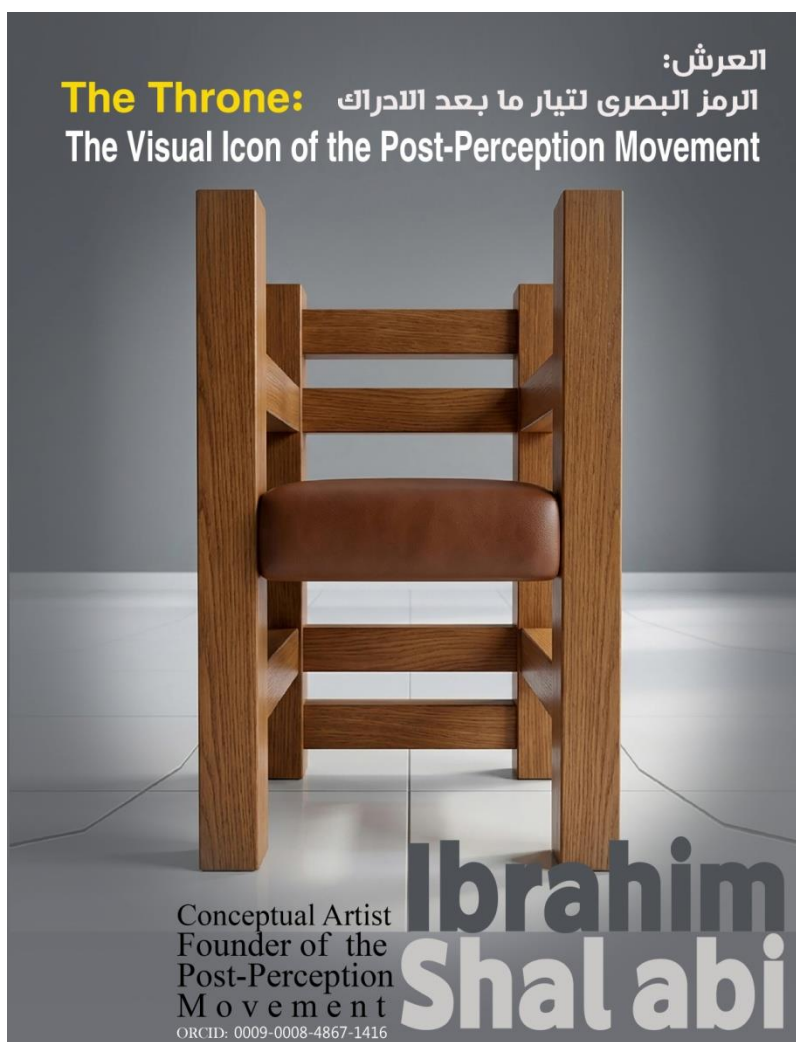


Post -Perception Movement



The Nine Principles of Post-Perception: A Simple Guide

Author: Ibrahim Shalaby (Founder of the Post-Perception Movement)

ORCID: 0009-0008-4867-1416

Published: May 19, 2026

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Introduction: A Question from the Nile Delta

When I was a child in Kafr El-Sheikh, a small village in the Nile Delta, I could not afford a box of colors. So I made my own paints from whatever I could find – crushed rocks, plant juices, mud from the fields. I painted on scraps of paper, on cardboard, on any surface that would hold an image.

But even then, as I mixed my homemade colors and drew the world around me, a strange question haunted me: *"Is what I see really what is there? Or is my eye deceiving me?"*

That question never left me. It followed me through decades of painting, through my years of collage and mixed media, through my self-developed technique of colored pastes when I could not afford oil paints, through my shift into photography and performance, and finally into the large-scale installations that now define my work.

Decades later, after thirty years of artistic practice – with eighteen solo exhibitions, over eighty group exhibitions, representation of Egypt at international events including the Malta Biennale 2026, and a PhD dissertation written about my work – I realized that childhood question had become the foundation of an entire art movement.

I called it **Post-Perception**.

Every artwork in this movement follows nine core principles. They are not complicated rules or academic formulas. They are simply the answers I found to that childhood question. Here they are – explained without philosophy, without jargon, for anyone who has ever doubted their own eyes.

Principle One: Perception is Fragile

For most of human history, we believed our senses were reliable windows onto reality. If you saw something with your own eyes, you could trust it. If you heard something with your own ears, it must be true.

This assumption is now dangerous.

Our senses are not sturdy gates to the truth. They are fragile systems – vulnerable to fatigue, to expectation, to cultural habit, and increasingly to algorithms designed specifically to exploit their weaknesses.

Think of a simple magic trick. The magician moves her hand one way, and your eyes follow. She moves the coin another way, and you miss it completely. Your eye did not fail because it is broken. It failed because it was predictable. It followed the pattern it expected.

Now imagine that same principle applied not by a magician on a stage, but by artificial intelligence systems trained on billions of images, designed to generate exactly what your eye expects to see – even when that thing never existed.

This is the crisis of our time. And Post-Perception begins by admitting a simple truth:

my senses can be fooled. And I need to know how.

In my work "This is Not a Pipe," I put viewers in a dark room and showed them eight images of pipes. Seven were generated entirely by artificial intelligence – no camera, no light, no original object. One was a photograph of a real pipe. I asked them to tell me which one was real.

Experts could not tell. Art students could not tell. Even I, the creator, had to check my own notes.

Perception is fragile. The first principle of Post-Perception is the courage to admit this.

Principle Two: Truth is Constructed

If perception is fragile, then truth cannot be a simple thing waiting out there to be discovered. Truth is not a mountain you climb to reach the summit. It is a building you construct with others, brick by brick, from the materials available to you.

Those materials include your sensations – what you see, hear, touch, taste, and smell. They also include your memory, your language, your culture, your expectations, and the context in which you find yourself.

Consider a simple example. If I show you a red circle, is it the same red circle at noon under bright sun as it is at midnight under a single candle? The paint has not changed. But your perception of it has changed completely. The truth of "redness" is not in the paint. It is in the relationship between the paint, the light, your eyes, and your brain.

This is not relativism – the lazy idea that "anything goes." It is an invitation to pay attention. If truth is constructed, then we have a responsibility to examine the materials of our construction. Who built the categories through which I see? What assumptions are hidden in my language? What expectations shape my experience before I even begin?

Post-Perception does not abandon truth. It insists on building it carefully, consciously, and with full awareness of its fragility.

In my installation "Isolation" – which was selected for the Egypt Pavilion at the Malta Biennale 2026 – I reconstructed a hospital isolation room from my own experience during

the COVID-19 pandemic. The walls are covered with pharmaceutical leaflets. A large circle made of 550 empty medicine boxes dominates the wall. A narrow bed holds a decaying sculpted head, from which 920 pills flow like blood through fragile arteries.

The work does not tell you what to feel about illness, isolation, or mortality. It gives you materials – sights, sounds, even the smell of surgical disinfectant – and invites you to construct your own truth from them. The truth is not in the work. The truth happens in you.

Principle Three: Language is Power

The words we use to name things are never neutral. When I say "this is a pipe," I am not simply describing reality. I am exercising authority. I am telling you how to see. I am closing off other possibilities.

In 1929, the surrealist artist René Magritte painted a picture of a pipe with the words "this is not a pipe" written beneath it. His point was philosophical: the painting is not the actual pipe. You cannot fill it with tobacco or smoke it.

In my work "This is a Pipe," I took his question further. I placed a real industrial blower – a machine that blows air, not smoke – in an art gallery. Beneath it, I wrote the words "this is a pipe." The blower was connected to electricity. Viewers could touch it, turn it on, feel the air rush out.

So was it a pipe? Of course not. It was a blower. But the words insisted it was a pipe. The gallery context insisted it was art. The viewer's own eyes insisted it was a machine.

Which authority do you trust? The words? The context? Your eyes? Or something else?

Language shapes perception before perception even begins. The words available to us determine what we can see, what we can think, what we can question. Post-Perception does not reject language – that would be impossible. But it reveals language as a tool of power, and it invites viewers to notice when words are doing more than describing.

In my work "This is a Urinal," I placed real urinals in a shopping mall bathroom. Above them, I hung signs saying "this is not a urinal" – with the mall's official logo, printed on professional plastic, looking exactly like an official regulation. Viewers were confused. Some walked away. Some stood frozen. Their bodies knew the urinal was a urinal. But the words – backed by the authority of the sign, the logo, the institution – told them otherwise.

Language is power. The third principle of Post-Perception is learning to recognize that power when it speaks.

Principle Four: Art is a Perceptual Laboratory

For much of art history, the purpose of art was to represent reality beautifully. A painting should look like what it depicts. A sculpture should honor its subject. A photograph should document truth.

Post-Perception proposes a different purpose. Art is not a mirror. It is a laboratory.

A laboratory is a controlled environment where you can test hypotheses, run experiments, and observe results safely. You can mix dangerous chemicals behind glass. You can study viruses under magnification. You can measure reactions without risking harm.

Post-Perceptual art is a laboratory for perception. It creates controlled situations where your senses are deliberately confused, your expectations are deliberately violated, and your assumptions are deliberately tested. And it does all of this in a safe space – an art gallery, a museum, a public installation – where the stakes are intellectual and emotional, not physical.

Why is this necessary? Because outside the laboratory, in the wild of the internet and social media and 24-hour news, the same perceptual manipulations are happening constantly – but without your consent and without your awareness. Algorithms are testing your attention. Deepfakes are testing your trust. Targeted advertising is testing your desires.

If you have never experienced perceptual confusion in a safe space, you will not recognize it when it happens in a dangerous one.

Over my thirty-year career, I have moved through many techniques – oil painting, collage, colored pastes I developed myself when I could not afford expensive paints, photography, performance, installation. Each technique was a different laboratory instrument. Each allowed me to test a different aspect of perception. But the purpose remained the same: to understand how the senses work, how they fail, and how they can be trained.

Art is a perceptual laboratory. The fourth principle of Post-Perception is taking that laboratory seriously.

Principle Five: The Viewer is a Partner

Traditional art treats the viewer as a spectator. You stand in front of a painting. You look. You admire. You leave. The painting is complete without you. Your presence changes nothing.

Post-Perceptual art rejects this model. In my work, the viewer is not a spectator. The viewer is a partner, a participant, and sometimes the subject of the experiment itself.

Consider "Adam's Apple." In this installation, you enter a dark room. A metal cage hangs from the ceiling by a worn rope. Beneath the cage, a mirror covers the floor. On the mirror, a single real apple sits in the center. The floor is uneven – some tiles sink slightly when you step on them. Texts on the walls ask questions: "Will you choose?" "Is falling the beginning?" "Do you see yourself in the reflection?"

The work is not complete until you decide. Will you walk toward the apple? Will you reach for it? Will you step back? Your choice, your hesitation, your curiosity, your fear – these are the materials of the artwork. Without you, the installation is just objects in a room. With you, it becomes a drama of perception, desire, and consequence.

The same is true of my work "This is Not a Pipe." After viewers watch the eight images and try to guess which pipe is real, they are invited to place their answer in a voting box. Those votes become part of an ongoing archive – "The Archive of Perception." Over time, the wall fills with thousands of votes, creating a living map of how human beings perceive reality in the age of AI.

You are not a spectator. You are a partner. Your perception is the material. Your choice is the evidence. Your participation completes the work.

The fifth principle of Post-Perception is this: the viewer matters. Not as a passive consumer of images, but as an active agent in the construction of meaning.

Principle Six: Perceptual Shock Opens the Door to Awareness

Most of the time, we perceive automatically. We do not decide to see. We simply see. We do not decide to hear. We simply hear. This automatic quality of perception is efficient – it allows us to navigate the world without constant effort.

But it also makes us vulnerable. Automatic perception follows predictable patterns. And anything that follows predictable patterns can be exploited.

Post-Perception uses a tool I call **perceptual shock**. This is a deliberate disruption of your automatic perception – a sudden confusion, a violation of expectation, a contradiction between what you see and what you hear, or between what you expect and what you experience.

The shock is not designed to harm you. It is designed to wake you up. For a brief moment, automatic perception stops. You are suddenly aware that you are perceiving. You notice your senses as senses, not as transparent windows. And in that moment of awareness, you have a choice: you can go back to sleep, or you can stay awake and ask questions.

In my work "Beyond Sound," I arranged ordinary household appliances – a blender, an iron, a fan, a hair dryer – in a space designed to look like a small electronics shop. Each appliance was connected to electricity. Viewers could touch them, turn them on, and hear what they produced.

But the sounds did not match the appliances. The blender produced the sound of ocean waves. The iron produced the sound of human breathing. The fan produced the sound of birds singing. The hair dryer produced the sound of a train passing.

The shock is immediate and physical. Your hand touches the blender. Your finger presses the button. Your ear expects a loud, mechanical grinding sound. Instead, you hear waves. For a fraction of a second, you are confused. Your automatic perception has failed.

That fraction of a second is the door. In that moment, you are not just hearing. You are aware that you are hearing. You are questioning. You are comparing. You are noticing the gap between expectation and reality.

Perceptual shock is not cruelty. It is a gift. It opens the door to awareness. The sixth principle of Post-Perception is walking through that door.

Principle Seven: Destruction Can Be Creation

We are taught to value preservation. Keep things intact. Do not break what is already built. Respect the past. Protect the heritage.

These are good instincts. But they can also become traps. Sometimes, the only way to truly understand an icon is to break it – not out of violence or nihilism, but out of a desire to see what it is made of, how it holds together, and what lies beneath its surface.

In my work "Beyond the Fountain," I did something that shocked many people. I took a replica of Marcel Duchamp's famous artwork "The Fountain" – a urinal that Duchamp had signed and presented as art in 1917, thereby changing the course of modern art forever. And in front of a live audience, I smashed it with a hammer.

But I did not smash it out of anger. I smashed it out of love – love for the questions that Duchamp had asked, and a desire to continue asking them. Duchamp had taken an ordinary object and asked "what is art?" I took that same object, now transformed into an

icon, and asked "what happens when an icon is destroyed? Does the meaning die? Or does it transform into something new?"

After the destruction, I gathered the broken pieces. I placed them in a glass case. And from the fragments, I constructed a new object – a fountain that actually worked, pumping real water, but broken, scarred, permanently marked by its own destruction.

The seventh principle of Post-Perception is this: destruction can be creation. Not always. Not automatically. But when done with care, with intention, and with philosophical seriousness, breaking something can be the most honest way of building something new.

This principle has deep roots in Arab-Islamic philosophy. The great thinker Al-Ghazali, writing a thousand years ago, subjected his own senses to radical doubt. He broke the assumption that seeing is believing. And from that destruction, he built a more sophisticated understanding of knowledge, perception, and truth.

I stand in that tradition. I break icons not to celebrate ruin, but to clear space for new construction.

Principle Eight: Art as Perceptual Immunity

A medical vaccine works by introducing a weakened or harmless version of a virus into your body. Your immune system learns to recognize the virus, fights it off, and builds memory cells. Later, if the real virus attacks, your body is prepared. It does not need to learn from scratch. It already knows how to respond.

Perceptual immunity works the same way.

Post-Perceptual art introduces controlled, harmless versions of perceptual confusion into your experience. A sound that does not match its source. An image that might be real or might be generated. A choice that has no clear right answer. A waiting that never ends.

These experiences are confusing. Sometimes they are uncomfortable. But they are safe. They happen in a gallery or a museum, not on a social media feed. You are prepared for them. You know you are in an experiment.

And because you have experienced perceptual confusion in a safe environment, your mind builds memory. It learns the patterns of deception. It recognizes the signs of manipulation. Later, when you encounter a deepfake video on the internet, or a generated image pretending to be news, or an algorithm trying to exploit your attention, your perceptual immune system responds faster. You do not need to learn from scratch. You already know how to doubt.

This is the deepest purpose of Post-Perception. It is not just an art movement. It is a training program for consciousness. It builds resistance to deception. It strengthens the critical muscles of the mind.

In my work "The Threshold of Beauty," I tested this principle directly. I filled a room with the sound of birds singing – one bird, then ten, then a hundred, then a thousand. The sound began as beautiful. It became overwhelming. Then it became painful. Each viewer had their own threshold – the point at which beauty turned into suffering. Some left early. Some stayed longer. Their choice was a measure of their perceptual immunity.

The eighth principle of Post-Perception is this: art can vaccinate the mind. It can train perception to be stronger, more skeptical, and more resilient in the face of a world designed to deceive.

Principle Nine: Constant Experimentation

The first eight principles might sound like a completed system – a set of rules that, once learned, can be applied mechanically.

They are not.

Post-Perception is not a closed doctrine. It is not a school you graduate from. It is not a formula you repeat. It is an open invitation to constant experimentation.

Every artwork in the movement is an experiment. Every viewer brings new perceptions. Every context changes the results. Every critic who writes about the work adds a new layer of meaning. Every artist who joins the movement extends its boundaries in directions I cannot predict and should not control.

I have been making art for over thirty years. I started with oil paintings in a small village in the Nile Delta. I moved through collage, colored pastes, photography, performance, installation, video. I founded a movement. I wrote books. My work was selected to represent Egypt at the Malta Biennale 2026. A PhD dissertation has been written about my practice.

And still, I do not have all the answers. I still ask the same question I asked as a child holding my first homemade paints: "Is what I see really what is there?"

The only difference is that now I know the question will never be fully answered. And that is not a failure. It is the condition of being alive, being conscious, and being human.

The ninth principle of Post-Perception is this: keep experimenting. Keep asking. Keep doubting. Keep building. The movement does not end. It only grows.

Conclusion: How These Principles Work Together

The nine principles of Post-Perception are not separate commandments. They are a single living system.

Perception is fragile – so we admit our vulnerability.

Truth is constructed – so we build it carefully.

Language is power – so we examine its authority.

Art is a laboratory – so we experiment safely.

The viewer is a partner – so we invite participation.

Perceptual shock opens awareness – so we design confusion carefully.

Destruction can be creation – so we break to rebuild.

Art is perceptual immunity – so we train resistance.

Constant experimentation – so we never stop.

These principles have guided my work for decades, long before I had words for them. They emerged from the soil of the Nile Delta, from the heat of Egyptian summers, from the silence of hospital isolation rooms, from the chaos of gallery openings and the solitude of the studio.

They are not European principles translated into Arabic. They are not ancient principles applied to modern problems. They are principles born from a specific life, a specific place, a specific journey – from a child without a box of colors to an artist representing his country on the world stage.

And yet, they are universal. Because every human being has senses. Every human being has been confused. Every human being has doubted their own eyes. Every human being has asked, at least once: "Is what I see really there?"

Post-Perception is my answer to that question. These nine principles are my gift to anyone who has ever asked it.

You do not need to be an artist to use them. You do not need a degree in philosophy. You do not need to understand the history of art or the intricacies of AI algorithms.

You only need one thing: the courage to doubt. And the willingness to keep asking.



About the Author

Ibrahim Shalaby (b. 1966, Kafr El-Sheikh, Egypt) is a visual artist, researcher, and the founder of the Post-Perception movement. His practice spans painting, collage, photography, performance, installation, and video art – a technical range developed over more than three decades of continuous experimentation.

Shalaby has held eighteen solo exhibitions and participated in over eighty group exhibitions across Egypt, Spain, Venezuela, Qatar, Iraq, and Malta. In 2026, his installation "Isolation" was selected for the Egypt Pavilion at the Malta Biennale – an international recognition marking the maturity of his artistic journey.

His work has been the subject of a PhD dissertation by Dr. Mahrous Ataki at Ain Shams University, and he has been documented by the Serbian Ministry of Culture in the publication "Ambassador of Art" (ISBN 978-977-6849-94-5). He has received critical praise from Dr. Shaker Abdel Hamid (former Egyptian Minister of Culture), Spanish critic Manuel Romero, and Spanish artist Antonio Alcázar.

Shalabi served as a former board member of the Egyptian Syndicate of Plastic Artists (Documentation Committee) and has received a state fellowship from the Egyptian Ministry of Culture (2015–2020). He is the author of the six-volume "Alban Alwan" series, including his autobiography and the theoretical foundation of Post-Perception.

ORCID iD: 0009-0008-4867-1416

Keywords: Post-Perception, Ibrahim Shalaby, contemporary art movement, nine principles, perceptual immunity, digital deception, AI art, deepfakes, perception crisis, Egyptian contemporary art, Malta Biennale

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